SAFE



RETURN

SERGEY ALEXEEV

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PORCH LIGHT

The tablet wanted a green answer.

It had wanted one since Mara Bell collected Eli Doolan from the river steps forty-three minutes earlier, and it had grown more insistent as the minutes passed. A red strip across the top of the screen said **CASE ACTIVE**. Beneath it a little wheel went round and round, looking for the van on a map of Berrin that had not been updated since the new roundabout went in. According to the map they were parked in a paddock.

Mara knew where the van was. It was idling halfway along Merino Street, under a paperbark that had dropped strips of bark across the windscreen like old receipts. On the left was the railway housing the government had sold off in the nineties, patched now with air conditioners and satellite dishes. On the right, behind a low wire fence, was Lorraine Doolan's fibro house. The porch light was on. A plastic chair lay on its side in the dirt. Nothing moved.

"Your nan's awake," Mara said.

Eli sat behind her, not in the passenger seat.

He had his hoodie up in spite of the heat. The air conditioner pushed out a lukewarm smell like the inside of a chemist. On the floor between his sneakers was the supermarket bag Samira had packed at River House: a bottle of orange drink, two packets of noodles, the second half of a cheese sandwich. He had eaten the first half in three bites on the river steps without taking his eyes off the water.

"She leaves it on," he said.

"The porch light?"

"For moths."

Mara looked at him in the mirror. His eyes were down. A scab ran along one cheekbone, old enough to have gone brown at the edges. She had asked about it once, at the steps, and he had said *nothing*, and she had let it go. She had been doing this job for eighteen months and the rule she trusted most had never been written into any manual: one question in the van. The second question was for offices.

The tablet chimed.

Eli glanced at it. "That thing telling on me?"

"It tells on everybody."

"Doesn't tell on you."

"You reckon?"

The Nightway app displayed his name, his date of birth, his referral source and his approved destination. Under **RISK FLAGS** it said **HISTORY OF ABSENCE, POLICE CONTACT, FAMILY CONFLICT**. The three phrases sat there as if they had been found in him by a blood test.

* * *

It had been an ordinary shift until then.

At twenty past seven she had collected a twelve-year-old called Braxton from the skate park, where he had spent an hour throwing his scooter at the half-pipe as if it owed him money, and driven him to his grandfather's place in Mitchell Street. The grandfather came to the door in a singlet with a tea towel over his shoulder and said, "Thanks, love, I'll take it from here," and he took it from there, one hand on the back of the boy's neck, steering him down the hall. Green. At nine she had picked up a girl from the hospital who had sat in emergency for four hours with a sprained wrist, waiting for a mother who was not coming, and driven her to an aunty who met them at the gate in a nightie and signed the tablet with her finger. Green. Most nights were like that. Most of the greens were green.

Samira had rung at ten to eleven.

"He won't go home and he won't say why," she said. "He's on the steps. He's not talking. He ate."

"That's talking, for Eli."

River House stood on River Road with its back to the levee, an old bowls club with a tin roof and a verandah that had been built for men in white trousers to watch other men in white trousers. Behind it a flight of concrete steps went down the levee bank to the water. The drop-in closed at nine. Most nights there was someone on the steps after that, because the steps were lit by the security light on the back of the building and the river was cooler than any house in Berrin.

Eli had been sitting three steps from the bottom with his knees up. The Berrin River was low, the colour of milky tea, and somebody's shopping trolley stood in the shallows with water running through its bars. A carp rolled in the dark and went under again. Samira was sitting on the top step with her shoes off and her phone in her lap.

"Lift?" Mara said.

He did not move.

"I can take you home or I can take you home the long way."

"Long way," he said, and got up.

The long way was not in the manual. Mara logged it as transport. She drove him out along the levee road to the weir, where the water went over the concrete lip in a thin brown sheet and the frogs were so loud they sounded mechanical. She drove past the cotton gin, dark and quiet, its yard empty of modules until picking started in a month. She drove past the abattoir that had closed when Eli was in primary school, its gates chained and its paddocks gone to Paterson's curse. Eli watched all of it.

The van's sliding door had stuck all last winter. Three hundred dollars of mechanics had failed to fix it. Then one evening, waiting outside the skate park for a lift, Eli had borrowed a butter knife from the River House kitchen and done something to the runner, and it had slid sweetly ever since. Mara thought of that every time she opened it.

Out past the saleyards he said, "You ever been to the beach?"

"Once. Port Macquarie. I was nine."

"What was it like?"

"I got sunburnt on the backs of my knees."

"Why the backs?"

"I lay on my stomach on the towel the whole time. I was scared of the waves."

He gave a short, surprised laugh.

"Nan reckons the sea's overrated," he said.

"Your nan's never been."

"That's what I said."

Then he was quiet again, and Mara turned the van back towards town.

* * *

Now she turned the engine off on Merino Street. The fan died and the heat came forward at once, relieved to have the van back. Somewhere beyond the houses a dog barked without conviction. February had baked the town hard. Even at quarter to midnight the bitumen gave off the day.

"Come on," she said. "I'll walk you in."

Eli did not move.

"You said drop-off."

"I am dropping you off."

"Drop-off means you stop the car and I get out."

"Safe return means I see you through the door."

"Since when?"

"Since always."

He smiled then, with one side of his mouth.

Mara's work phone began to vibrate in the cup holder.

The name on the screen was **KIERA W.** She picked it up.

"Kiera?"

At first there was only traffic and a wet, broken breathing. Then a girl whispered, "He's here."

"Who's here?"

"You know."

Mara straightened. "Where are you?"

"The servo. Back bit. Near the gas bottles."

"Is he with you now?"

"No. He's out front. He seen me go round. Mara, just come."

A man shouted something in the background. Kiera stopped breathing into the phone.

Mara could see the place without trying: the fluorescent forecourt on the highway, the trucks sliding in and out, one teenage cashier behind thick glass after eleven. Behind the building there was a cage of gas bottles and a strip of dirt that ended at a drainage channel. Kiera Walsh had turned fourteen in December. She had been twelve the first time Nightway picked her up, from the same servo, and she had sat in the back eating Samira's noodles dry out of the packet and asked whether she could have the van lady's number. *For emergencies,* she had said. *Not for chatting.* She had used it fourteen times since. Mara had counted, once, on a bad night. The man she was frightened of was Corey Hollis, who was twenty-three, or twenty-two, depending on which record you read, and who had once put a girl's head through a bathroom door at a party in the Gidgee Street flats and been fined four hundred dollars for it.

"I'm coming," Mara said. "Stay inside. Get behind the counter if she'll let you. Don't go out the back."

"He'll smash it."

"Let him smash it. You stay where there's cameras."

Kiera hung up.

Mara started the engine. The tablet woke brighter on its mount. Eli was watching her.

"That little girl?" he said.

"You know Kiera."

"She's not little."

"She's fourteen."

"So?"

"So get out."

For a moment neither of them moved. Mara could feel the van pulled two ways at once: thirty metres to Lorraine's lit porch, three kilometres to the highway. The rules were very clear when printed. You did not leave a young person until an authorised adult had taken responsibility. You

did not transport a second young person while the first case remained open. You did not, under any circumstances, use the van for emergency response. There was a flowchart on page nine of the manual, and at the top of it, in a grey box, was a small grey figure with no face. Every arrow on the page ran down from him. There was no box for a second child.

"I'll watch you go in," Mara said.

Eli lifted the supermarket bag and opened the sliding door. It ran the way he had made it run. Hot air and crickets came into the van.

"You got your key?"

He patted the front pocket of his shorts.

"Show me."

He made a face but took it out: a single key on a blue plastic tag. Lorraine had cut it for him after he climbed through the bathroom window one night and broke the flyscreen.

"Straight in," Mara said. "No disappearing."

"Where would I disappear?"

"Eli."

He stepped down and shut the door. The van rocked. Mara put it into drive and kept her foot on the brake.

He crossed in front of the headlights. For a second he was all white soles and thin legs. Then he reached the footpath and became a dark shape under the paperbark, and he turned towards Lorraine's gate.

The phone vibrated again.

KIERA W.

Mara answered. There was screaming this time, and it was not Kiera. A man's voice, close to the phone, said, "Come out, you little lying cunt."

"Ring triple zero," Mara said loudly, to the cashier, to anyone. "I'm two minutes away."

She looked up. Eli had reached the gate. One hand was on it.

The tablet offered four outcomes in large rectangles.

SAFE RETURN
TRANSFER TO AUTHORISED SERVICE
YOUNG PERSON DECLINED
OTHER

OTHER opened a form with eleven compulsory fields. **YOUNG PERSON DECLINED** sent an alert to the duty manager and the police liaison officer. If she left the case open, the tablet would keep chiming, no new pickup could be started, and in the morning Samira would have to explain an unresolved transport to Denise, and Denise would have to explain it to Sydney.

Mara pressed **SAFE RETURN**.

A second screen appeared.

HANDOVER CONFIRMED?

She saw Eli push the gate inward.

She pressed **YES**.

The red strip disappeared. The case went green. Mara took her foot off the brake before the gate had swung shut behind him.

* * *

Kiera came round the side of the service station at a run.

Mara had barely stopped when the girl yanked at the door. Her hair was half out of its braid and there was blood on one knee. She wore a grey singlet, a pair of men's football shorts and no shoes.

"Open it!"

Mara hit the release. Kiera climbed in and dragged the door shut with both hands.

A man came round the front of the building. He was bare-chested, narrow at the waist and wide at the shoulders, with a word tattooed in fancy letters above his navel that Mara could not read from the van. He raised one arm as if hailing a bus.

"That's my missus," he called.

Mara locked the doors.

"Drive," Kiera said.

Corey Hollis slapped the side of the van with his open hand. "You can't kidnap her, you black bitch."

Kiera dropped below the window. Mara reversed hard enough to send an empty drink bottle rolling out from under the passenger seat. Corey

followed for two steps, then stopped as the Nightway logo came round into the forecourt light: a blue river and a brown road. He took out his phone and started filming.

"Good," Mara said. "Make sure you get the number plate."

She swung onto the highway. In the mirror the service station shrank to a white island in the dark.

Kiera stayed on the floor.

"Seat," Mara said.

"No."

"Seatbelt."

"He'll follow."

"He's on foot."

"His brother's got the ute."

Mara watched the road behind them. A B-double came out of the dark, high beams flooding the van, then pulled into the overtaking lane and roared past with its load of hay. No ute.

"Where's Sharon?" Mara asked.

"Dunno."

"You're meant to be at Sharon's."

Kiera laughed once from the floor. "Am I?"

"Your mum's?"

"No."

"River House?"

"You got beds now?"

Mara said nothing.

Kiera pulled herself up onto the back seat. She was shaking, though the van was hot. On her upper arm, finger marks were coming up: four dark ovals and a thumb.

"Did he do that?"

Kiera looked out the window.

"Do you need the hospital?"

"No."

"Police?"

"No."

"We have to take you somewhere."

"Take me Maccas."

"It's closed."

"Then I got nowhere."

The tablet chimed for a new case. Kiera leaned forward between the seats and read the screen upside down.

"Put safe return," she said.

"You haven't returned anywhere."

"Neither did Eli."

Mara looked at her in the mirror. "What's that mean?"

"Nothing."

"Kiera."

The girl folded her arms and turned her face to the glass. The streetlights moved over it, one after another.

* * *

Samira was still at River House because her shift ended when the last child was somewhere, not when the roster said midnight. She met them at the side door in socks, holding a first-aid kit, and did not ask a single question until Kiera's knee was clean.

Then she asked one, over Kiera's head, while she was peeling the backing off a dressing.

"Eli go in all right?"

"Yeah," Mara said.

They found a foam mattress in the programme room, which had been the bar when the building was a bowls club and still had the long counter and the brass foot-rail. They rang Sharon Pollard, Kiera's aunt and her authorised carer, eleven times. At one-thirty Sharon answered, furious at being woken, and said Kiera had chosen to leave and could choose to come back in daylight like a normal person. At one-forty-five the police said they had no power to hold a girl who was not in danger and no female officer on until six. At ten past two, Mara rang Denise Barlow at home.

Denise answered on the second ring, which meant she had not been asleep.

"Let her sleep," she said. "But don't write the word accommodation anywhere."

"What do I write?"

"Crisis support. Short duration."

"How short?" Samira asked. She was listening on speaker.

"Until morning."

"That's accommodation."

"It's morning in four hours," Denise said, and hung up.

Kiera lay under a donated Broncos blanket with her eyes shut, listening.

Mara made her a Milo in the old club kitchen. The urn was cold and the kettle took forever. On the wall above the cereal boxes hung the honour boards the bowls club had left behind when it folded: varnished timber, gold leaf, **MEN'S SINGLES CHAMPION**, **LADIES' PAIRS**, **PRESIDENT'S TROPHY**, the names going back to the nineteen-fifties in a careful signwriter's hand. Nobody at River House had ever taken them down. Denise said the bowlers' grandsons might come back for them one day.

Kiera opened one eye when Mara came in with the mug.

"How many sugars?"

"Two."

"Samira does three."

"Samira's soft."

Kiera sat up and took the mug in both hands. She looked at Samira in the doorway, then made her own eyes very wide and her voice very gentle and said, "And how are we tracking, emotionally, on a scale of one to ten?"

It was so exactly Samira that Mara laughed out loud.

"I do not say *tracking*," Samira said.

"You said it Tuesday."

"I said it once."

"Once is how it starts," Kiera said, and drank her Milo, and lay down again.

By three she was asleep, one bare foot sticking out from under the blanket.

Mara sat at the end of the old bar with the tablet and completed her notes.

Young person collected from public location following family conflict. Transported to service for crisis support. No injury disclosed. Follow-up required.

She did not write about the man at the service station who had called Kiera his missus. If she wrote it, it would become a mandatory report, and Kiera would learn never to ring Mara again. Mara read the note through twice. She saved it as a draft.

Before she went home she opened the list of her night's cases.

Eli's was green.

The map showed a pin on Lorraine's house and the words **HANDOVER CONFIRMED 23:48**.

Mara remembered the gate moving inward. She held her thumb on the screen until his name slid off the list of things that were hers to finish.

* * *

She did not have to drive home along Merino Street. It was a block out of her way. She took it anyway.

At twenty to four the street was empty and the sprinklers were on in the yards of the people who could afford water. Lorraine's porch light was still burning. Behind the front curtains the television changed colour, blue and white and blue again. The plastic chair was still on its side in the dirt.

Mara slowed to a walking pace.

The light was on. The television was on. Lorraine fell asleep in her chair most nights; everybody on Merino Street knew that, because everybody on Merino Street had at some time been told off by Lorraine through a flyscreen door.

Mara took her foot off the brake and drove home.

Her house was a weatherboard on Levee Street with a mortgage she had taken over when she bought Joel out, and a front step that had dropped two inches since. The kitchen light was on. Her mother was asleep on the lounge under the crocheted rug she had brought from her own house in the first month of the separation and never taken back, her glasses on her chest and the television on mute. On Thursday nights Val slept over so that Noah was never alone in the house, and on Thursday nights, whatever time Mara came in, Val woke up and asked the same question. She had asked it in exactly the same voice, Mara's sister said, every night Mara and Courtney had come home as teenagers, and every night of the fifteen years their father drove road trains.

Val opened her eyes without moving anything else.

"All home?"

Mara stood in the doorway with her bag on her shoulder and the tablet charger in her hand. Through the wall she could hear the fan in Noah's room knocking on every fourth turn.

"All home," she said.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Sergey Alexeev is a Senior Research Associate at UNSW's Nura Gili Centre for Indigenous Programs and an Adjunct Senior Lecturer at the Sydney Clinical Trials Centre, University of Sydney.

His research covers health, crime, addiction, public policy and service systems, and the evaluation of what programs and policies actually achieve. His academic work appears in journals including *Addiction* and the *Journal of Law and Economics*. He is an Associate Editor of the *International Journal of Mental Health Systems* and serves on the editorial board of the *International Journal of Drug Policy*.

Safe Return brings those worlds together in a single story about what happens when institutional records and human lives diverge.

HOW THE NOVEL CAME TOGETHER

Safe Return grew out of my research, publications, research notes and professional experience across Australian health, justice, public policy and community services, including co-design and community-engaged research.

I developed the novel under my creative direction, bringing together observations and material from fields that are usually studied separately. Generative AI tools, including ChatGPT and Claude, helped synthesize this material and assisted with drafting and editing the prose.

I directed the story's development and undertook substantial editorial review and revision.

https://www.alexeev.pw/safe-return/